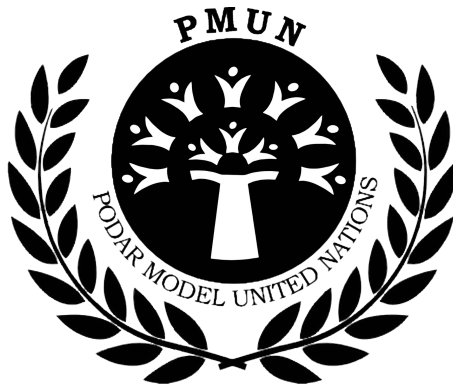




PMUN

BACKGROUND GUIDE - 3

Topic: Addressing the Crisis of Food Insecurity in Conflict Areas

Committee: Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO)



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Food insecurity in conflict areas is one of the most urgent humanitarian crises in the world. Wars and armed conflicts destroy farms, block food deliveries, collapse economies, displace families, and prevent humanitarian aid from reaching people in need. In an MUN, delegates must discuss how the international community can protect civilians, ensure access to food, and prevent famine.

A. Understanding the Issue

The world faces a devastating and growing humanitarian challenge. Countries and regions experiencing armed conflict – including parts of Sub-Saharan Africa, the Middle East, South Asia, and Eastern Europe – face extreme levels of food insecurity as wars, civil conflicts, and political instability destroy farmland, disrupt supply chains, and displace millions of people from their homes and livelihoods.

Conflict is today the single biggest driver of hunger in the world. When fighting breaks out, farmers cannot tend their fields, markets shut down, roads are destroyed, and food aid struggles to reach those who need it most. Agricultural infrastructure – including irrigation systems, storage facilities, and livestock – is frequently damaged or deliberately targeted during conflict.

At the same time, the communities most affected are often the most vulnerable – children, women, the elderly, and refugees who have fled their homes with nothing. Food insecurity in conflict zones does not just cause hunger; it drives malnutrition, disease, child mortality, and long-term developmental harm to entire generations.

However, the challenge extends beyond the conflict itself. Even when fighting stops, recovering food systems takes years. Displaced farming communities struggle to return, landmines contaminate agricultural land, and economic collapse makes rebuilding nearly impossible without sustained international support.

B. Key Conflict Areas Facing Food Insecurity

Major hotspots include:

Sudan

Gaza

Yemen

South
Sudan

Haiti

Democratic
Republic of Congo

Syria

These areas face a mix of war, displacement, economic collapse, and climate shocks.

C. Why This Issue Is Important Globally?

Food insecurity in conflict areas is directly connected to humanitarian crises, global migration, economic instability, and long-term development. Hunger caused by conflict does not stay within borders – it drives refugee movements, destabilises neighbouring countries, and creates cycles of poverty and violence that are extremely difficult to break.

- **Public Health:** Malnutrition weakens immune systems, increases disease, and causes millions of preventable deaths, especially among children under five.
- **Human Rights:** Access to food is a fundamental human right recognised by the United Nations. Conflict-driven hunger is a violation of that right.
- **Global Migration:** Food insecurity is one of the leading causes of forced displacement, contributing to refugee crises that affect countries far beyond the conflict zone.
- **Economic Development:** Hunger reduces productivity, disrupts education, and traps communities in long-term poverty cycles.
- **SDG 2:** The UN aims to achieve Zero Hunger globally by 2030. Conflict is the single greatest obstacle to reaching this goal.

D. Key Statistics & Trends

- As of 2024, approximately 282 million people across 59 countries face acute food insecurity, with conflict being the primary driver in most cases.
- Around 60% of the world's hungry people live in countries affected by conflict and fragility.
- The UN World Food Programme (WFP) estimates that people in conflict zones are up to 20 times more likely to face severe hunger than those in stable countries.
- Countries like Sudan, Yemen, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Syria, and Haiti are among the most critically food-insecure in the world.
- Child wasting — a severe form of malnutrition — affects over 13 million children in conflict-affected regions, according to UNICEF.
- The economic cost of hunger caused by conflict is estimated at over \$3.5 trillion annually in lost productivity and healthcare burden globally.

These statistics highlight the strong connection between political stability, food access, public health, and long-term human development.

E. Learn About Your Committee – FAO

What Does FAO Do?

- Leads international efforts to defeat hunger and improve nutrition worldwide
- Collects and shares data on food production, agriculture, and food security
- Provides technical assistance and capacity building to member states
- Develops international standards and guidelines for food safety and agricultural practices
- Coordinates emergency food and agricultural responses in crisis situations

Powers:

- Can recommend agricultural and food security policies to member states
- Can coordinate international food aid and emergency agricultural responses
- Can set global standards for food safety, trade, and sustainable agriculture
- Can mobilise funding and resources for food crisis interventions

Limitations:

- Cannot directly enforce policies or laws in sovereign nations
- Depends on member states and donors for funding and implementation
- Effectiveness in conflict zones is limited by access restrictions and security concerns
- Relies heavily on cooperation with other UN agencies such as WFP and UNICEF

Past Actions:

- Led global food security monitoring through the State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World report
- Coordinated emergency agricultural assistance in Yemen, Syria, and the Horn of Africa
- Supported the Committee on World Food Security (CFS) and global food governance frameworks
- Promoted the Voluntary Guidelines on the Right to Food

F. UN Action and Frameworks

I. Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948)

Established the right to an adequate standard of living, including food, as a fundamental human right. This declaration laid the moral and legal groundwork for all future international efforts to address hunger and food insecurity.

Key Features:

1. Recognised food as a basic human right
2. Set the foundation for international humanitarian law
3. Encouraged nations to protect civilians in conflict
4. Established international accountability for human welfare

Why it Matters:

1. Created a universal standard for human dignity
2. Gave international bodies the mandate to intervene in humanitarian crises
3. Remains the basis for all UN food security frameworks

Limitations:

1. Not directly enforceable in international law
2. Compliance depends entirely on political will
3. Many conflict states have repeatedly violated these principles without consequence

Insight: Delegates can discuss whether international human rights frameworks are strong enough to protect food access in active conflict zones.

II. Rome Declaration on World Food Security (1996)

World leaders committed to halving the number of hungry people by 2015. Held at the World Food Summit in Rome, this declaration brought food security to the centre of international development policy and led to the strengthening of FAO's mandate.

Key Features:

1. Committed nations to reducing global hunger
2. Placed food security firmly in the international development agenda
3. Strengthened FAO's role in monitoring and coordinating global food policy
4. Encouraged national food security action plans

Why it Matters:

1. First major modern global commitment to ending hunger
2. Increased international investment in agricultural development
3. Encouraged cooperation between governments, NGOs, and international agencies

Limitations:

1. Targets were not legally binding
2. Progress was uneven, with conflict-affected countries falling far behind
3. Implementation depended entirely on national governments

Insight: Delegates may debate whether political commitments without enforcement mechanisms are sufficient to address hunger in conflict zones.

III. UN Security Council Resolution 2417 (2018)

The first UN Security Council resolution to explicitly link conflict and food insecurity, condemning the use of starvation as a weapon of war. This landmark resolution recognised that deliberately starving civilian populations is a war crime under international law.

Key Features:

1. Explicitly condemned the use of hunger as a weapon of war ·
2. Called for humanitarian access to conflict-affected populations ·
3. Required the UN Secretary-General to report on conflict-driven food insecurity ·
4. Reinforced international humanitarian law protections for civilian food systems

Why it Matters:

1. Marked a major shift in international recognition of conflict-hunger links
2. Created a legal basis for holding parties to conflict accountable for food-related war crimes
3. Strengthened advocacy for humanitarian access in active conflict zones

Limitations:

1. Enforcement depends on Security Council consensus, which is often blocked by vetoes
2. Many violations have occurred without meaningful consequences
3. Access to conflict zones for aid agencies remains severely restricted

Insight: Delegates may debate whether political commitments without enforcement mechanisms are sufficient to address hunger in conflict zones.

IV. Sustainable Development Goal 2 – Zero Hunger (2015)

Commits all UN member states to ending hunger, achieving food security, improving nutrition, and promoting sustainable agriculture by 2030. Conflict zones represent the greatest obstacle to achieving this goal globally.

Key Features:

1. Global commitment to ending hunger by 2030
2. Targets food access, nutrition, agricultural sustainability, and smallholder farmer support
3. Connects hunger with poverty, climate change, and conflict
4. Encourages international cooperation and investment in food systems

Why it Matters:

1. Placed hunger at the centre of the global development agenda ·
2. Encouraged countries to align national policies with food security goals ·
3. Increased international funding for agricultural development in fragile states

Challenges:

1. Conflict continues to reverse progress in the most vulnerable countries ·
2. Climate change is compounding food insecurity in already fragile regions ·
3. Financing gaps remain large, particularly for post-conflict agricultural recovery

Insight: Delegates may debate how the international community can accelerate progress on SDG 2, specifically in conflict-affected nations.

V. The Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction (2015)

Although primarily focused on natural disasters, the Sendai Framework is highly relevant to conflict-driven food crises because it promotes resilient food systems, early warning mechanisms, and rapid humanitarian response – all critical in conflict-affected areas.

Key Features:

1. Promotes disaster-resilient infrastructure, including food systems
2. Encourages early warning and early action for food crises
3. Supports recovery and rebuilding of agricultural systems after shocks
4. Connects humanitarian response with long-term development planning

Why it Matters:

1. Helps countries build food systems that can withstand both conflict and climate shocks
2. Encourages investment in early warning systems for food crises
3. Supports rapid post-conflict agricultural recovery

Limitations:

1. Primarily designed for natural disasters, not conflict situations
2. Political dimensions of conflict-driven hunger are difficult to address through disaster frameworks
3. Requires significant national capacity that fragile states often lack

Insight: Delegates can explore how resilience frameworks designed for natural disasters can be adapted to address the unique challenges of conflict-driven food crises.

VI. The Food Systems Summit (2021)

Convened by the UN Secretary-General to catalyse action on transforming global food systems. The summit acknowledged conflict as one of the key systemic shocks threatening food security worldwide and called for more resilient, equitable, and sustainable food systems.

Key Features:

1. Addressed food systems holistically – from production to consumption
2. Recognised conflict as a major systemic driver of food insecurity
3. Encouraged innovative financing for food security in fragile states
4. Promoted the inclusion of conflict-affected communities in food system planning

Why it Matters:

1. Brought renewed global attention to the structural causes of hunger
2. Created momentum for national food system transformation plans
3. Encouraged collaboration between governments, civil society, and the private sector

Limitations:

1. Outcomes were non-binding commitments
2. Progress on implementation has been slow, especially in conflict-affected regions
3. Critics argued that corporate interests were given too much influence in the summit process

Insight: Delegates can discuss whether transforming global food systems is possible without first addressing the political causes of conflict.

G. Country Positions

Countries involved in global healthcare and foreign aid have different priorities, responsibilities, and challenges. While donor countries often focus on global health security, diplomacy, and economic interests, many low-income nations have challenges in healthcare access, sustainable funding, and dependence on external financial assistance. Understanding these positions is important for delegates when forming alliances, negotiating resolutions, and proposing realistic long-term solutions.

I. Yemen

Yemen is experiencing one of the worst food crises in the world, driven by years of devastating civil war. The ongoing conflict has destroyed agricultural infrastructure, blocked food imports, and displaced millions of farming families. Yemen imports over 90% of its basic food supplies, making it extremely vulnerable to supply chain disruption.

Key Policies and Context:

1. Heavily dependent on international food aid
2. Limited national agricultural capacity remaining
3. Ongoing peace negotiations have had limited success

National Interests:

1. Immediate humanitarian food assistance
2. Ceasefire and political stability to allow agricultural recovery
3. International funding for rebuilding food infrastructure
4. Protection of food aid corridors

Challenges:

1. Active conflict severely limits humanitarian access
2. Economic collapse has destroyed purchasing power
3. Infrastructure damage makes food distribution nearly impossible in many areas
4. Deep political divisions complicate international intervention

ii. Sudan

Sudan faces a catastrophic food crisis triggered by the outbreak of war between the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces in 2023. Millions have been displaced, farmland has been abandoned, and food markets have collapsed across large parts of the country, pushing Sudan to the brink of famine.

Key Policies and Context:

1. Ongoing armed conflict displacing agricultural communities
2. Limited government capacity to respond to the crisis
3. Heavy dependence on international humanitarian organisations

National Interests:

1. Immediate ceasefire and humanitarian corridors
2. International food aid and agricultural support
3. Protection of civilian food infrastructure
4. Long-term investment in agricultural resilience

Challenges:

1. Active and rapidly shifting conflict makes aid delivery extremely dangerous
2. Government fragmentation limits coordinated response
3. International attention has been inconsistent
4. Climate shocks, including drought, compound existing food insecurity

iii. Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC)

The DRC has one of the world's largest and most complex food crises, driven by decades of overlapping armed conflicts in its eastern regions. Despite having some of the most fertile agricultural land in Africa, millions go hungry because farming communities are displaced by violence and unable to access their land safely.

Key Policies and Context:

1. Multiple armed groups are controlling different parts of the country
2. Active UN peacekeeping mission (MONUSCO) with limited effectiveness
3. Significant international food aid presence through WFP and FAO

National Interests:

1. Security and stability in conflict-affected agricultural regions
2. International support for rebuilding local food markets
3. Protection of smallholder farmers and displaced agricultural communities
4. Long-term investment in rural development and infrastructure

Challenges:

1. Extreme geographical complexity and poor infrastructure
2. Dozens of armed groups make conflict resolution extremely difficult
3. Corruption and governance failures hinder aid delivery
4. Displacement of farming communities has caused long-term agricultural collapse in many regions

iv. Ukraine

Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 triggered a global food security crisis, as Ukraine and Russia together supply a significant portion of the world's wheat, sunflower oil, and corn. The conflict devastated Ukrainian farmland, disrupted global grain exports, and caused food price spikes that worsened hunger in import-dependent countries worldwide.

Key Policies and Context:

1. Major global agricultural exporter severely affected by conflict
2. UN-brokered Black Sea Grain Initiative attempted to protect grain exports
3. Significant international support for Ukraine's agricultural recovery

National Interests:

1. Protection of agricultural infrastructure from military attack
2. Restoration of safe export corridors for grain and food commodities
3. International support for post-war agricultural rebuilding
4. Accountability for deliberate destruction of food-producing infrastructure

Challenges:

1. Ongoing conflict continues to damage farmland and agricultural facilities
2. Landmines are contaminating large areas of agricultural land
3. Economic disruption affecting farming communities
4. Global ripple effects are creating political pressure on international food aid budgets

v. Ethiopia

Ethiopia has faced overlapping food crises driven by the Tigray conflict, recurring drought, and economic instability. The conflict in northern Ethiopia caused mass displacement, destroyed agricultural livelihoods, and blocked humanitarian access, creating one of the worst food emergencies in the country's recent history.

Key Policies and Context:

1. Peace agreement signed in 2022, but recovery remains slow
2. Active FAO and WFP programmes supporting agricultural rehabilitation
3. Government committed to food security but is facing severe resource constraints

National Interests:

1. Post-conflict agricultural recovery and rehabilitation
2. International funding for food system rebuilding
3. Early warning and rapid response systems for future food crises
4. Addressing the root causes of conflict to prevent future food emergencies

Challenges:

1. Slow implementation of peace agreement provisions
2. Continued insecurity in some regions is limiting agricultural recovery
3. Climate shocks, including drought and flooding, are compounding food insecurity
4. Large displaced population struggling to return to farming

H. Case Studies

1. Yemen – WFP Emergency Food Assistance

The World Food Programme's response in Yemen represents the largest humanitarian food operation in the world, reaching millions of people in active conflict zones through a combination of food rations, cash assistance, and nutrition programmes.

Source: <https://www.wfp.org/countries/yemen>

2. DRC – FAO Smallholder Agricultural Recovery

FAO's programmes in the DRC have focused on restoring agricultural livelihoods for displaced farming communities by providing seeds, tools, and training to help families return to food production as soon as conflict subsides.

3. Ukraine – Black Sea Grain Initiative

The UN-brokered Black Sea Grain Initiative (2022–2023) allowed Ukraine to resume grain exports through safe maritime corridors, demonstrating the role of international diplomacy in protecting global food supply chains during conflict.

Source: <https://www.un.org/en/black-sea-grain-initiative>

I. List of Agendas

1. Should humanitarian food aid be guaranteed safe passage through active conflict zones under international law?
2. Can the international community hold warring parties legally accountable for the deliberate destruction of food systems?
3. Should post-conflict agricultural recovery be included as a mandatory component of all UN peace agreements?
4. How can the FAO improve early warning systems to prevent food crises before they reach famine levels in conflict-affected regions?

J. References & Recommended Reading

UN & International Bodies

- FAO – Food and Agriculture Organisation: <https://www.fao.org/>
- UN SDG 2 – Zero Hunger: <https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal2>
- World Food Programme: <https://www.wfp.org/>
- UNICEF – Nutrition in Emergencies: <https://www.unicef.org/nutrition>
- UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs: <https://www.unocha.org/>
- Committee on World Food Security: <https://www.fao.org/cfs/en/>

Key Reports & Data

- State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (annual FAO report):
<https://www.fao.org/publications/sofi/>
- Global Report on Food Crises: <https://www.fsinplatform.org/>
- FEWS NET – Famine Early Warning Systems Network: <https://fews.net/>
- IFPRI – International Food Policy Research Institute: <https://www.ifpri.org/>

Country-Specific

- Yemen – WFP Country Profile: <https://www.wfp.org/countries/yemen>
- Ukraine – UN Food Crisis Response: <https://www.un.org/en/black-sea-grain-initiative>
- Ethiopia – WFP Country Profile: <https://www.wfp.org/countries/ethiopia>

International Law & Frameworks

- UN Security Council Resolution 2417: <https://www.un.org/press/en/2018/sc13354.doc.htm>
- Right to Food – FAO Guidelines: <https://www.fao.org/right-to-food/en/>